

STAGE SIX • COMMUNICATION: SPEAKING, READING & WRITING

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Six • Communication: Speaking, Reading & Writing

PURPOSE

Stage Six runs across six sessions — Written Communication, Verbal & Presentation Skills, Listening/Reading & Comprehension, Interpersonal & Networking Communication, Feedback/Reflection & Self-Assessment, and Communication Systems & Tools — each gets one icebreaker below, built directly from that session's actual content.

Every one of these does real, if lighthearted, diagnostic work: exposing a weak subject line, normalizing unscripted speaking, demonstrating how much gets lost between hearing and retaining, revealing one-directional small talk, practicing the compliment-critique balance, or rehearsing active note selection — all before the session's formal teaching begins.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Six Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

The Subject Line Game

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask each participant to privately pull up the last email they sent and read aloud only the subject line.
2. As a group, vote: does this subject line alone tell you what the email is actually about, or would you have to open it to find out?
3. Quick tally: how many subject lines genuinely passed the test?

WHY THIS WORKS

A fast, slightly exposing warm-up that makes the core problem behind FIRST I1 (Professional Email Sent) and I39 (Email Etiquette Audit) immediately concrete before any formal teaching begins.

SESSION 2

60-Second Impromptu Warm-Up

TIME: 10 min

1. Prepare 5–6 light, easy prompts on slips of paper (e.g., “convince us pineapple belongs on pizza,” “describe your morning like a nature documentary”).
2. Call volunteers up one at a time to speak for 30 seconds on a random prompt, no prep time.
3. Applaud everyone regardless of performance — the point is normalizing unscripted speaking before this session's real practice begins.

WHY THIS WORKS

This previews the exact discomfort of FIRST I29 (Impromptu Speaking Drill) in a genuinely low-stakes, silly context, which makes the real version later feel less intimidating by comparison.

SESSION 3

One-Minute Recall Test

TIME: 8 min

1. Read a short, unfamiliar paragraph aloud to the group once, at a normal pace, with no notes allowed.
2. Give everyone 60 seconds to write down everything they can remember, then compare notes with a neighbor.
3. Discuss: what's the gap between what was actually said and what people retained?

WHY THIS WORKS

A quick, humbling demonstration of how much genuinely gets lost between hearing and

retaining, which sets up this session's entire focus on active listening and comprehension.

SESSION 4

Two-Minute Mixer

TIME: 10 min

1. Have participants stand and pair up with someone they don't know well.
2. Give each pair exactly 2 minutes total (60 seconds each) to have a genuine conversation using only questions, no statements about themselves allowed.
3. Debrief: how did question-only conversation feel different from a normal introduction exchange?

WHY THIS WORKS

This surfaces, playfully, how much of typical networking small talk is one-directional broadcasting rather than genuine exchange — exactly the gap FIRST I12 (Networking Conversation) addresses.

SESSION 5

Compliment/Critique Swap

TIME: 8 min

1. In pairs, each person shares one thing they're currently working on (a project, a skill, anything real).
2. Partner gives one genuine compliment and one genuine, kind area for growth — both required, neither optional.
3. Quick full-group check: was it harder to give the compliment or the critique?

WHY THIS WORKS

A light, fast way to practice the exact balance FIRST I25 (Professional Feedback Given) requires, before the session's more substantial feedback and reflection work begins.

SESSION 6

Note-Taking Speed Round

TIME: 8 min

1. Read a moderately dense paragraph aloud once, fairly quickly.
2. Give participants 90 seconds to condense what they heard into no more than 3 bullet points.
3. Compare a few examples: whose bullets actually capture the core content versus just fragments of sentences?

WHY THIS WORKS

This directly rehearses the active selection skill FIRST I52 (Active Note-Taking System) is built around, making the difference between passive transcription and active structuring immediately visible.

